

Photographs by ABID BHAT



crowds huddled under the tall floodlights. But the final overs didn't come. Instead, fate bowled a disaster that has shaken up Kashmir's sports world.

"Players haven't been paid, staff hasn't been paid, the hotel hasn't been paid. The league management is nowhere to be seen, they haven't been answering anyone's calls. It's just us guys on the ground trying to find a way out of the situation," a harried Melissa Juniper, an umpire of the England Cricket Board officiating in the IHPL, told media. She and her fellow umpires and all the players, stars and locals, were left with no option but to negotiate with the hotel management to walk out freely. Over Rs 51 lakh went unpaid. The local food and broadcasting agencies were also left in the lurch with unpaid dues worth lakhs.

Notes of scepticism had not been lacking even before. The league offered a valuation of Rs 2.5 crore each to its eight teams, with payment contracts to international players and some key faces. But most of the local players got no formal commitments, triggering hostility among a few. But a huge ad blitz featuring global stars like Gayle meant a majority of the local cricketers couldn't resist. They, too, are going back home with egg on their face.

Former India player Parveez Rasool, who took Kashmir to cricket's main stage, got only 10 per cent of his contract fee. "That was during the contract-signing, nothing later. We continued playing matches on hollow assurances," he told INDIA TODAY. Gayle et al, too, are believed to have got part of their fees. "Who would have doubted them?" asks Rasool. "The league had credible names of Indian cricket, like Surinder Khanna and Ashu Dani."

Takeaways

- **'Indian Heaven Premium League' collapses mid-way as organisers ditch Kashmir**
- **International players, staff and umpires stuck; local players unpaid too**

Kashmir's nearly four-decade-long international cricket jinx was broken in October 2024, when the Legends League Cricket saw matches in Srinagar: a lineup of global stars, thousands of spectators. IHPL, expected to be a replay, fetched poor response from the outset. Unsold tickets forced organisers to go for promotion and discounts tactics with local content creators. Many point to the poor revenue generation as the reason for the fiasco, which has led to a loss of crores for stakeholders.

THE SLOG OVERS

It's like a startup flopping amidst a gold rush that always had its fair share of hustlers. With a government push post 2019, cricket emerged as an industry in Kashmir. Big businessmen swaggered in, funding leagues and tourneys, earning rich dividends. In August, south Kashmir's Pulwama hosted its first ever day-night cricket gala. Proof of Kashmir's rampant unemployment is right there, said wags, as crowds swarmed the venue for the finals, bringing traffic to a total halt in the district for hours.

But it's an uneven windfall. Promises are getting broken, though nervous local players do not complain. Rural talent is unable to access the big league. "We can't pay thousands as entry fees. Even a basic tournament goes for Rs 10,000. We stick to village-level events," says Arif Hussain Bhat, a passionate cricketer from Zamalgam, a village in picturesque Verinag. The government has been spiffying up sports infra, but it's virtually off limits for the locals as they remain booked for major events.

The IHPL is a fruit of this skewed boom. Sports minister Satish Sharma, who inaugurated it, promises strict action, but the BJP is bowling beamers at the Omar Abdullah regime, saying the scam has "brought shame". The organisers, Parminder and Manpreet Singh, have ducked out of sight. ■